PROPOSAL · 13 OCTOBER 2026 · SOHO SQUARE GARDENS, W1D 3QH

The Substation

Variant A · a perfume museum beneath Soho Square

Below the lawn there is a 300 m^2 machine hall: a 1928 DC converter substation that became a Blitz shelter, sealed since about 2015. This proposal turns it into a small, hosted perfume museum with a London flagship for Tiziana Terenzi. This page sets out one of four design directions, with its floor plan and long section.



SOHO SQUARE GARDENS · 1132

FLOOR

297 m²

3,200 sq ft, 2015 particulars

PLAN

30 × 10 m

estimate, east–west

DEPTH

3.5–4.5 m

below the lawn, estimate

BUILT

1928

substation, WWII shelter

STAIRS

2

west hatch + Grade II hut

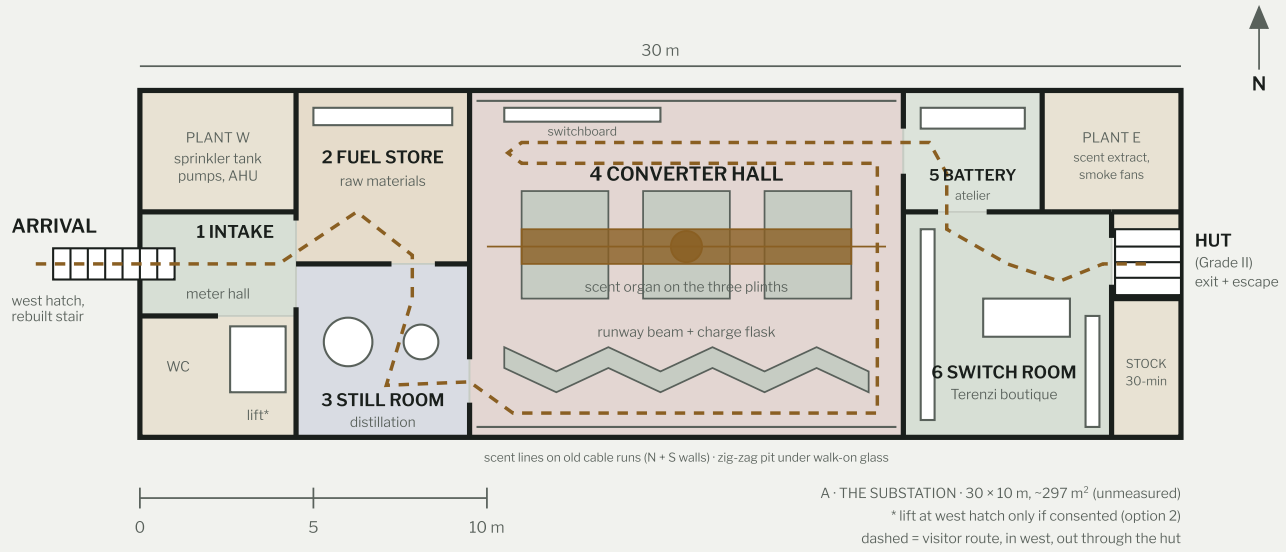
VISITORS

60–70

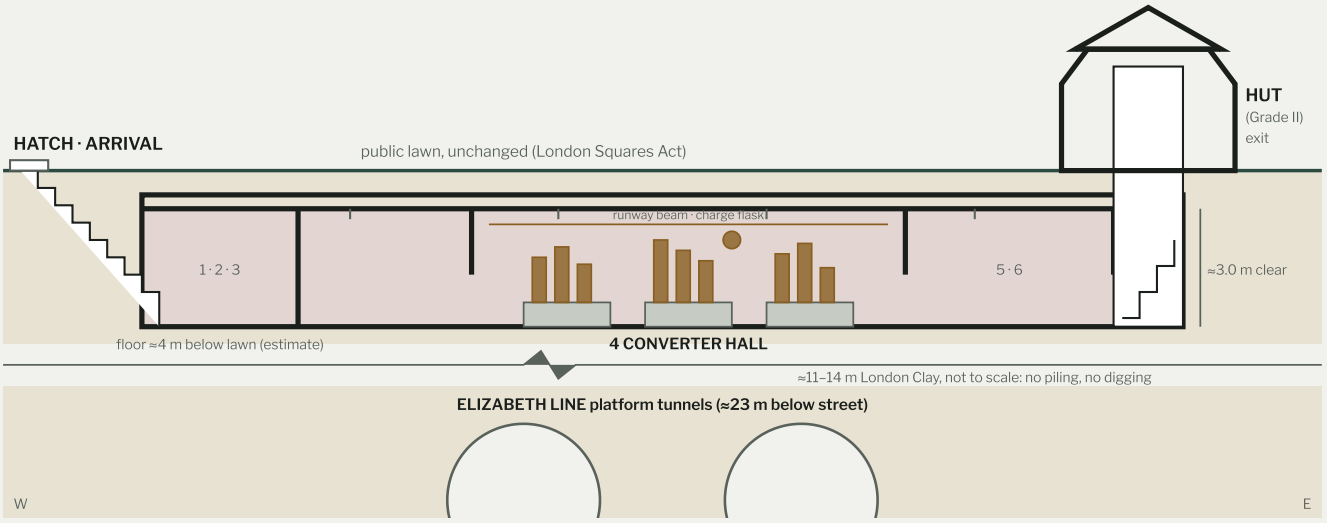
at once, both stairs rebuilt

A The Substation

In 1928 this room turned the city's current into power for Soho. Now it turns raw materials into scent, and you throw the switch.



Floor plan, 1:200 at 20 px/m. 30 × 10 m hall, about 297 m². West stair = arrival, hut stair = second exit.



Long section, west to east. Depths are estimates until measured.

The idea

The space under the western lawn was most likely never dug as a shelter. It is the Charing Cross Electricity Supply Co.'s 1928 DC converter hall (1,500 kW), and its plinths, pits, cable runs, porcelain cleats and chain-hoist beam are still there. This variant stops apologising for the machine hall and restores it as an industrial cathedral. Perfume is told as energy: **raw materials (fuel) → distillation**

(generation) → accord (conversion) → charge (the bottle you carry out). The three old machine plinths carry a new instrument, the Converter, a brass-and-porcelain scent organ that "plays" an accord in pulses. The old cable runs become scent lines, the runway beam carries the finished charge across the hall, and the visit ends in the Tiziana Terenzi Switch Room. Terenzi began as a candle works (Cereria), so the story starts with wax: the first energy that made light.

The visit, room by room

Hosted groups of up to 14, one every 15 minutes, about 55 minutes in all. Everyone enters at the west hatch and leaves through the hut: one-way, so groups never cross.

1. **Intake** (meter hall), 4 min. A cool, almost scentless room in white glazed brick. Your ticket is a stiff 1920s-style *meter card*. One note only: warm beeswax from a single (flameless) Terenzi candle under glass, "before the current, there was wax". Sound: a distant 50-cycle hum that grows as you walk east.
2. **Fuel Store** (raw materials), 8 min. Brass coal-scuttle hoppers along the wall, each holding one natural: Calabrian bergamot, iris root, vetiver, labdanum, oud, a tincture of ambergris. Lift a lid and a short dry-air puff reaches you; nothing hangs in the room. You punch your meter card at the two you like most.
3. **Still Room** (distillation), 8 min. A working 20-litre electric copper alembic runs a timed steam distillation (rose or lavender in season, water and plant matter only, no ethanol). You see the condenser glass fog, hear an amplified drip and smell the hot, green, unfinished distillate: perfume before it is beautiful.
4. **Converter Hall** (the accord), 14 min. The full 12.5 × 10 m volume, cleared back to steel beams and lit like a turbine hall. The Converter sits on the three original plinths: nine brass "pipes" with porcelain insulators, each with a sealed scent cartridge. You walk the south aisle on walk-on glass over the lit zig-zag cable pit, round the organ, to the switchboard on the north wall. **The Throw** (see below) fires the accord in four waves: top, heart, base, then all together.
5. **Battery Room** (charge), 6 min. Your punched card is read at a brass bench. A host fills a 10 ml "cell" (brass-capped vial) from three components matched to your punches: your own small charge to carry. Evenings, it is the atelier.
6. **Switch Room** (Tiziana Terenzi boutique), 15 min, free time. A 1920s switchboard wall in walnut, brass and porcelain: each knife switch you close lights one fragrance bay and presents a tester blotter. Then up the hut stair into the middle of the square.

The signature moment

The Throw. Every 15 minutes one visitor, chosen by their meter card, pulls a reproduction 1920s knife switch (low-voltage, interlocked; it only *looks* dangerous). The hall goes dark; a deep hum rises from transducers inside the plinths, so you feel it in your feet; blue-white light runs along the old cable runs from the switchboard to the organ; the Converter's pipes light one after another as each fires its note; and the original chain-hoist trolley carries a glowing glass *charge flask* along the runway beam overhead to the Battery Room door. Four minutes, one accord, one photograph from the glass floor looking up at the flask crossing the beams.

Making it super cool

- **The Converter (scent organ).** Nine sealed cartridges in brass bells at nose height, dry-air micro-dosing triggered per note (Scentys/Olfacom-class hardware, not nebulised oil). Each bell has a **downdraught extract** at the plinth base, so a note clears in about 60 seconds. One accord per show keeps the visit inside the "about 7 distinct scents" limit from the research.
- **Scent lines on the cable runs.** New frosted-glass and brass tubes clipped to fresh rails *beside* the original porcelain cleats (cleats untouched). Light pulses travel along them; scent is released only at nodes by the doors, so the "current" is seen everywhere and smelt only where intended.
- **The runway beam lives again.** The trolley moves a 3–4 kg lit glass flask (no liquid above people; the flask is a resin replica). If the original beam fails its load test, a slim new track runs alongside and the original stays as heritage.
- **Walk-on glass over the zig-zag pit.** The machine pit is lit from inside and filled with the raw materials of room 2 in bulk (sealed under the glass): you walk over the fuel.
- **Sound as current.** A tuned hum (low, never loud) in the plinths, and the Elizabeth line rumble 11–14 m below folded into the score instead of fought.
- **Inert, sealed 1920s materials.** White glazed brick tile, brass, porcelain, bakelite-look controls, sealed concrete floor. They are the switchgear look *and* the right answer to odour soak (the research says bare brick will hold every scent). One "as found" bay of original wall stays behind glass.
- **Meter card ritual.** Your ticket is punched room by room; the punches set your Battery Room charge and, if you buy, are printed on the bottle label as your "reading".
- **Light on DMX.** Warm carbon-filament glow by day, cold arc-blue only during the Throw; slow swells, no strobe (photosensitivity).

Above ground

- **Arrival:** the rebuilt steel hatch by the western railings, flush and closed outside slot times. The host meets the group at the west gate 3 minutes before the slot; the ticket QR opens the hatch. Slots are 15 minutes apart, so at most one group (≤14) stands at the railings and nobody queues on the lawn.
- **Exit through the hut:** you climb into the centre of the square, which is the second surprise of the visit. The hut stays a bare protected stair head (no sign, no display, no till); its doors are opened by staff only in operating hours.
- **Garden etiquette:** nothing new on the lawn, no signage beyond a small brass plate at the hatch, no deliveries through the garden in public hours (stock comes in by trolley through the west hatch before opening). Night events need the garden managers' agreement to keep the west path and hut route open after the square closes (to be negotiated; not assumed).

Formats & money

All figures are **estimates**, prices include VAT.

FORMAT	PRICE	NOTES
Current (day visit, 55 min, hosted)	£28 (£22 concession); £10 of it redeemable in the Switch Room	14 per slot, every 15 min, Tue–Sun 11:00–19:00
Night Load (nocturne, extended Throw, non-alcoholic pairing)	£65	2 slots × 14, Thu–Sat after hours
Charge atelier (make a 30 ml extrait from the organ's accord)	£140	6 people, in the Battery Room plus hall
Commission (Terenzi London bespoke, from the meter-card profile)	from £1,200; full bespoke on application	by appointment
Private hire / launches of the whole hall with a custom Throw	£3,500–£6,000 per evening	events only if the two-stair (Scenario C) capacity is approved; otherwise ≤60 total

- **Capacity:** 14 per slot; with three groups in sequence plus boutique browsers and staff the peak stays under 60 below ground.
- **Terenzi's role:** the Switch Room is a Terenzi monobrand boutique (the brand has none in London); Terenzi operates it, keeps the margin and pays a turnover rent, or the operator buys wholesale. Terenzi also co-curates the Converter's accords each season.
- **Non-obvious line: "1132"**, a numbered annual extrait composed on the Converter and named after the door stencil "SOHO SQUARE GARDENS / 1132", sold only in the Switch Room, plus licensing the Throw show (organ score + light cue file) to Terenzi's other boutiques for launches.
- **Rough annual revenue (estimate):** about 40,000 day visitors at ~45% slot occupancy → tickets ≈ £0.85m net; boutique 25% conversion × £160 ≈ £1.3m net; Night Load ≈ £0.2m; atelier ≈ £0.25m; hire ≈ £0.2m; bespoke and 1132 ≈ £0.25m. **Total ≈ £3.0m net, range £1.8m–£3.8m.** Capex likely at the upper half of the dossier's £2.4m–£5.3m range because of the Converter and beam works (organ itself perhaps £0.3m–£0.6m, unquoted).

Fit with the constraints

- **Fire:** designed for Scenario B (rebuilt west stair in, rebuilt hut stair out, ≤60 below ground), with sprinklers plus mechanical smoke extract (ADB s.18 route). One-way flow keeps travel distances short and both exits on the route. Perfume stock in a 30-minute store; organ cartridges hold millilitres, not litres; the alembic distils water and plant matter only, on electric heat.
- **Heritage:** plinths, pits, cleats, beam and hut are kept and read as the exhibit. The organ stands on a steel frame bearing on pads (reversible, no fixings into the plinths); scent lines and lights on new rails; one bay left as found. The hut changes only by the stair rebuild needed anyway (LBC).
- **HVAC:** six zones; the Hall, Fuel Store and Still Room are each slightly negative to the route, with carbon-filtered extract; the organ's downdraught is the main extract in the hall, ducted at floor level (whether old conduits can carry it is speculation until surveyed). The still adds heat and moisture: local hood plus dehumidification. Acoustic lining for train rumble.
- **Accessibility:** step-free only if a platform lift is achieved, at the hut (Scenario B) or the west hatch (option 2, consent-dependent); if only the hut lift, wheelchair users enter there and do the route east-to-west with a host. Ramps over dwarf walls; the glass over the pit is flush. Refuges at both stairs. Hum kept below discomfort levels; quiet, low-scent "sensory" slots weekly; no live flame anywhere.
- **Honest gap:** the 30 × 10 m footprint, the position of the plinths and the beam's capacity are all unmeasured. The plan places three plinths in the middle third as an assumption.

Risks

- **The runway beam may not be certifiable** to move anything over visitors. Fallback: a new parallel track or a fixed flask that "charges" with light alone; the moment still works, less spectacularly.
- **Scent clearance in a 125 m² hall** may be slower than a 15-minute cycle needs, leaving residue that muddies the next Throw. Prototype the organ and downdraught at full scale before fit-out; reduce to two waves if needed.
- **UK Power Networks may still hold rights or live equipment** in part of the old substation (dossier §8), which could take a plinth or the switchboard wall out of the plan.

Prepared by Mia for Alessandro Ticchi, 13/10/2026. Dimensions are estimates from photographs and 2015 press reports. Nothing here has been measured. Site photos: 28DaysLater, Forever Changes, Subterranea Britannica, Evening Standard (2015). Revenue figures are rough estimates for discussion.